

The first 12 hours

The moment you've been dreaming of for nine months has finally arrived and now you're holding your baby in your arms! So what happens next?

Your experience of the first 12 hours will depend on your labor and birth and local procedures, but here is an account of what usually occurs.

The first hour after the birth As long as they are well, your baby can be put in your arms and you can make the most of these first magical moments. The doctor or your partner will cut the umbilical cord after a few minutes, or once it stops pulsating. You may feel elated, relieved, or just exhausted. Don't be alarmed if you start to vomit, shake vigorously, or feel too exhausted even to hold your baby. These are all very normal postbirth sensations.

If your baby is fine and you want to breastfeed, put them to the breast, but they may just nuzzle at first. Snuggle them close, skin to skin—the warmth of your body is all they need right now.

At 1, 5, and 10 minutes, your baby will be observed and given an [Apgar score](#). They will be wiped with a soft towel, their fingers and toes checked, and their weight and head circumference measured. They will also have a hearing test in the first hours.

Shortly after your baby is born, you will deliver the placenta, naturally or with medication (see [Delivering the placenta naturally](#)). Medication to contract the uterus after the birth will shorten the third stage and has been shown to reduce the risk of postpartum hemorrhage.

If your perineum tore, or you had an episiotomy (a cut to ease your baby out), you may need stitches. You'll be given a local anesthetic, unless you already have an epidural, so you don't feel a thing. Your partner can hold your baby and sit close by while you are stitched.

It is recommended that newborn babies have a vitamin K injection, to prevent them from developing serious problems with bleeding. Stores of vitamin K, which is needed for blood clotting, are often low in newborns, and vitamin K deficiency bleeding is a serious cause of bleeding in newborns and up to 6 months of age. Newborns who do not receive a vitamin K shot are 81 times more likely to develop severe bleeding.

2–3 hours Time to refuel: many women say their first drink of water and snack after giving birth are the best they've ever tasted... enjoy.

If you're feeling fine and there are no concerns about your condition, you'll likely be moved to the maternity ward, where you'll spend the remainder of your time in the hospital. You'll be taken there in a wheelchair with your baby in your arms. (In some hospitals, you'll never leave the room where you deliver; some labor and delivery rooms act as postpartum rooms, as well.)

3–4 hours You'll be sweaty, sticky, and want a shower, which you can have if you didn't have an epidural. Ask a nurse or your partner to walk with you if you're feeling wobbly.

5–6 hours The first time you urinate it can sting, especially if you had stitches, so pour a cup of warm water over your perineum as you urinate. The hospital needs to know everything is in good working order before you leave its care. You'll need to use sanitary pads to soak up the vaginal blood loss (lochia).

7 hours This might be the first chance you've had to look at your baby's tiny toes, scrunched-up legs, or fine head of hair. There may be traces of greasy vernix on their skin. Perhaps they have long, flaky fingernails that need trimming or a downy fuzz of hair called lanugo on their back.